

Sex For An Xbox 360?

Two Boston women allegedly offered sex in exchange for an Xbox 360 in an ad on www.craigslist.org. The posting has since been removed. But, all people seemed to want to know was, "There are women who want an Xbox?"



P2P-ing Pilot Predicament

Security codes to restricted areas for 16 Japanese airports were leaked on to the Internet because a 29-year-old Boeing 767 JAL co-pilot's home computer had the P2P software Winny installed! The co-pilot's computer had been infected by a virus.



Escape

THE PC CRITICS

My PC Loves This Movie!

Imagine if your PC could analyse a movie and tell you it was great, and a must-watch. Or how about a book? Yes, software developers sure do work on weird things. In this case, the software isn't really meant for you, but rather, movie producers and book publishers.

With box offices raking in less than before, this software could be a godsend for big-budget producers and directors.

Professor Ramesh Sharda of Oklahoma State University, the developer of the software, told Reuters, "We are trying to forecast the success of a movie based on things that are decided before a movie has been made."

So basically, the idea is to input some details of the movie, such as its rating by critics, the other films

releasing at the same time, strength of the cast, genre, special effects, whether it is a sequel, and the number of theatres it plans to open in. The software then computes the success or failure rate.

The rating ranges from a "flop," for a movie that will

gross less than \$1 million, to a "blockbuster," for movies that *should* earn in excess of \$200 million.

Sharda uses a neural network to analyse the possible outcomes of the input data. And the results aren't very far off the mark! Since the inception of the idea, Sharda has analysed 800 films that released, and his results were spot on—37 times out of a 100. The remainder of the results were just one category higher or lower in terms of expected grosses at the box office.

However, the point to ponder is whether film makers really need to start looking at software to decide whether to make a film or not! If this trend catches on, we'll never see any movies that break

the mould, or never see any newcomers as actors! Can we really afford to leave the creativity to a few PCs?

Very soon, India could start seeing movies that only star known names, and newcomers will be left out. Perhaps the majority would love that, but what about encouraging new talent, taking those risks, and making movies that are good, rather than movies that will sell?

If that's not enough, www.lulu.com, a publishing Web site, claims to have developed a way for software to analyse the *New York Times* bestseller list over the last 50 years and then decide whether an upcoming book has a good title!

Drop us a line and voice your opinions—tell us whether you feel it's a good idea to let such software decide the movies we see or the books we read.

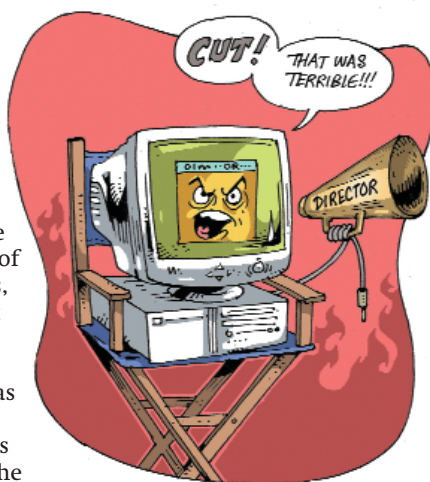


Illustration: Harsho Mohan Chatteraj

Win!

My Desktop

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SMILING SOFTWARE

What Was Mona Lisa Smiling About?

Scientists at the University of Amsterdam in The Netherlands and the University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign claim to have developed an emotion recognition software that